

SYLLABUS: LANGUAGE, RACE, AND IDENTITY IN THE UNITED STATES TODAY

November 23, 2019 Syllabus Language and race, syllabus

Language, Race, and Identity in the United States Today
GESM 130g – Seminar in Social Analysis – 35427R
University of Southern California
Hebrew Union College Jerome H. Louchheim School of Judaic Studies

Fall 2019 Professor Sarah Benor
Tuesday and Thursday, 9:30-10:50am E-mail: benor@usc.edu
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Office: Hebrew Union College, Rm. 21 (basement) Office Hours:
Syllabus and other materials available on Blackboard by appointment (don't be shy!)

Course Description

In the United States, members of racial, ethnic, and immigrant groups indicate their identities partly through the use of multiple languages and by speaking English in distinctive ways. This class uses theories and methods from sociolinguistics, linguistic anthropology, and sociology to explore the interplay among language, race, and identity in the contemporary American setting. Students will become critical consumers of qualitative and quantitative research on language and identity, and they will gain experience conducting their own basic sociolinguistic analysis.

Several questions will drive the class:

1. How do Americans of various racial and ethnic groups use language and other cultural practices to express both their Americanness and their distinctiveness?
2. How much control do we have over how we are viewed by others in terms of race and ethnicity?
3. In what ways are people evaluated negatively or discriminated against because of their distinctive language?
4. How do racial/ethnic identities intersect and interact with other social dimensions, like socioeconomic class, gender, sexuality, and religion?
5. Why do some people speak in more "standard" ways than others? Why do some individuals speak very differently in different situations?
6. What counts as empirical evidence in the study of language, race, and identity?

Groups on the syllabus include African Americans, White Americans, Latino Americans, Jewish Americans, South Asian Americans, and Asian Americans.

Course Requirements

Regular attendance and participation are essential for the creation of a stable, stimulating learning environment. I will take roll at the beginning of each class; each absence over two will result in a reduction of one point off your final grade. You will be held responsible for all material presented in class, as well as all reading assignments. I suggest that you exchange contact information with two classmates to form a study group. Get detailed notes and handouts in the event that you are absent. Because class discussion will revolve around the readings, you will be expected to complete all of the reading in a thoughtful way before each class. Notice that prepared class participation is worth 20% of your grade.

This is how the participation grade is determined:

- a. Quantity (regular participation in classroom discussions)
- b. Quality (comments show understanding of and engagement with the material)
- c. Evidence of preparation (reading in an engaged way)
- d. Overall contribution to the class (not overbearing, not distracted, no inappropriate use of electronics, contributes positively to the class vibe)
- e. Presentation for Assignment #2

II. Assignments (to be turned in via Blackboard):

- Assignment #1: Language and identity autobiography (2-3 pages)
- Assignment #2: (in pairs): Analysis of a film or TV show, focusing on issues of language and identity (5-6 pages)
- Assignment #3: Research paper (7-9 pages)

III. Midterm quiz (in-class)

IV. Final exam (take-home, open-book)

Grading

Your grade in the course will be calculated as follows:

- Prepared class participation 20%
- Writing assignments 50% (10%, 20%, 20%)
- Midterm quiz 10%
- Final exam 20%

Grading scale:

- 93-100: A
- 90-92: A-
- 88-89: B+
- 83-87: B
- 80-82: B-
- 78-79: C+
- 73-77: C
- 70-72: C-
- 68-69: D+
- 63-67: D
- 60-62: D-
- 59 or below: F

Required Books (available in the book store or online)

1. Language and Linguistic Diversity in the US: An Introduction, by Susan Tamsai and Lamont Antieau, 2014, Routledge Press. ISBN-10: 9780415806688. (Called "Language" below)
2. Raciolinguistics: How Language Shapes Our Ideas About Race, edited by H. Samy Alim, John R. Rickford, and Arnetta F. Ball, 2016, Oxford University Press. (Called "Raciolinguistics" below.)
3. Other readings are available on ARES (<https://reserves.usc.edu/>), indicated here by (A), Blackboard (<https://blackboard.usc.edu/>), indicated here by (B), or on other websites.

Note: some of the films to be shown in class include "R-rated" themes and language.

Academic Integrity

As defined in the Student Conduct Code, plagiarism includes: "The submission of material authored by another person but represented as the student's own work whether that material is paraphrased or copied in verbatim or near verbatim form." The submission of material subjected to editorial revision by another person that results in substantive changes in content or major alteration of writing style; and "improper acknowledgment of sources in essays or papers." In accordance with these standards, plagiarism will result in an "F" grade for the course and possible suspension or expulsion from the University. (See Scampus, the Student Guidebook.) Because of the serious penalties for plagiarism, you should ensure that any writing you submit represents your own assertions and abilities and cites any texts in an open and honest manner. In academic assignments, writing is assumed to be the original thoughts and words of the student unless otherwise noted (i.e., material from other sources is clearly and properly cited). In other words, be careful to document your sources (print or online), even when you are only making use of data or ideas rather than a direct quote.

Accommodation of Disabilities

Any student requesting academic accommodations based on a disability is required to register with Disability Services and Programs (DSP) (see a letter of verification for approved accommodations can be obtained from DSP (<https://dsp.usc.edu/>). Please be sure the letter is delivered to me as early in the semester as possible.

Laptop/Tablet/Phone Policy

Unless otherwise noted, students in this class may not use computers, tablets, phones, or other electronic devices with internet capability during class, even if internet/wireless is turned off. Phones must be in bags and either powered off or in Do Not Disturb mode (not on vibrate, as that is also disruptive). Students are expected to bring books or printed readings to class and to take notes by hand. If you have a disability that requires you to type notes, or if you have a personal issue that requires a phone to be visible (such as a family emergency), please let the instructor know.

This policy is based on years of allowing devices and finding that some students were unable to avoid distraction. It's also based on academic evidence: In an experiment simulating a classroom experience, Sana, Weston, and Cepeda (2012) found that "participants who multitasked on a laptop during a lecture scored lower on a test compared to those who did not multitask (but did just as well on note taking), and participants who were in direct view of a multitasking peer scored lower on a test compared to those who were not." When presenting ideas in class, I often gauge students' comprehension and responses by watching their facial expressions. If students were reacting to a website or a friend's message, rather than to the classroom conversation, this would be confusing.

How to Reach Me

I am available to help you with your research, writing, presentation, and comprehension of the course material. The best way to get in touch with me is via e-mail (benor@usc.edu), or you can talk to me after class.

Schedule

Readings are to be completed before the class session under which they are listed.

Introduction: Language, race, and identity

TUESDAY, AUGUST 27

Video to be shown in class: Saturday Night Live – Leslie Jones and Louis C.K. – This is How I Talk: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FBPXvqYpGCM>

Language and identity autobiographies

THURSDAY, AUGUST 29

- O'Hearn, Claudine Clavier. 1998. "Introduction." In Half and Half: Writers on Growing Up Biracial and Bicultural, ed. by Claudine C. O'Hearn. New York: Pantheon. vii-xiv. (B)
- Wamba, Philippe. 1998. "A Middle Passage." In Half and Half: Writers on Growing Up Biracial and Bicultural, ed. by Claudine C. O'Hearn. New York: Pantheon. 150-169. (B)

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 3

- Álvarez, Julia. 1998. "A White Woman of Color." In Half and Half: Writers on Growing Up Biracial and Bicultural, ed. by Claudine C. O'Hearn. New York: Pantheon. 139-149. (A)
- Daneqah, Meri Nana-Alma. 1998. "I'm Not an Alien." In Half and Half: Writers on Growing Up Biracial and Bicultural, ed. by Claudine C. O'Hearn. New York: Pantheon. 99-111. (A)

To be distributed and read in class: "Double Consciousness," excerpt from DuBois, W.E.B. 1903. "Of Our Spiritual Strivings." In The Souls of Black Folk. Penguin Classics. Paragraphs 3 and 4.

Linguistics: Basic principles

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 5

Language, Chapters 1-2 (1-42).

Language variation

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 10

Language, Chapter 6 (119-142).

Race and ethnicity

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 12

- Reyes, Angela. 2010. "Language and ethnicity." In N. Hornberger and M. Lee, eds., Sociolinguistics and Language Education. New York: Multilingual Matters. 398-412 (not entire article; you'll read the rest in a few weeks). (A)
- Urciuoli, Bonnie. 1996. Exposing Prejudice: Puerto Rican Experiences of Language, Race, and Class. New York: Routledge. "Racializing and ethnicizing." 15-18. (A)

Sunday, September 15, 11:59pm: Assignment #1 due via Blackboard

Racial malleability

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 17

- Kroeger, Brooke. 2002. "Not some social agenda struggle." In Passing: When People Can't Be Who They Are. New York: Perseus. 11-42. (A)
- Sweetland, Julie. 2003. "Unexpected but authentic use of an ethnically marked dialect." Journal of Sociolinguistics 6/4: 514-536. (A)

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 19

Raciolinguistics, 1-7, 33-50 (Alim, Intro excerpt; Transracialization).

Raciolinguistics, 51-64 (Roth-Gordon, Malleability).

Find pairs for Assignment #2 in class

African Americans

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 24

Language, Chapter 7 (143-166).

Comedy excerpt shown in class: Key and Peele, "Phone Call": <http://www.cc.com/video-clips/qwrh7y/key-and-peeel-phone-call>

Proposals for Assignment #2 due via Blackboard (one per pair)

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 26

Rickford, John Russell and Russell John Rickford. 2000. Spoken Soul: The Story of Black English. New York: Wiley, "Comedians and Actors." 57-72. (A)

Rickford, John Russell and Russell John Rickford. 2000. Spoken Soul: The Story of Black English. New York: Wiley, "The Crucible of Identity." 221-229. (A)

Comedy excerpts shown in class: Adele Givens, "Fake Bitch" (DVD).

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 1

No class: Rosh Hashanah

Language, Chapter 9 (186-207) (American multilingualism, melting pot/salad bowl, to be discussed in a few weeks).

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 3

Raciolinguistics, 153-169 (Blake, Heterogeneity).

Raciolinguistics, 203-219 (Pedraza, Stereos).

Raciolinguistics, 241-253 (Paris, Schools).

Model presentation by Professor Benor

Language attitudes

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 9

Language, Chapters 3, 8 (43-63, 167-185).

Writing skills presentation by Professor Benor

Standard language ideology, language discrimination, accent hallucination

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 10

Lippi-Green, Rosina. 2012. English with an Accent: Language, Ideology, and Discrimination in the United States. Routledge Press. 66-74, 90-97, 155-166, 322-329. (A)

Student presentation

Sunday, October 13: By now you should have watched your film/show at least twice, taken detailed notes (incl. quotes), and created an outline for your paper (not turned in)

Education and schools

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 15

- Reyes, Angela. 2010. "Language and ethnicity." In N. Hornberger and M. Lee, eds., Sociolinguistics and Language Education. New York: Multilingual Matters. 412-420 (you read the first part a few weeks ago). (A)
- Barrett, Rusty. 2013. "Be yourself somewhere else: What's wrong with keeping undervalued English out of the classroom?" Chapter 3 of Other People's English: Code-Meshing, Code-Switching, and African American Literacy. Vershawn Asanti Young et al., eds. New York: Teachers College Press. 33-54. (A)

Midterm review sheet distributed

Student presentation

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 17

No class: October recess

Sunday, October 20, 11:59pm: Assignment #2 due via Blackboard (one per pair)

Assignment #2 Contribution Evaluation due via Blackboard (one per student)

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 22

Bucholtz, Mary. 2011. White Kids: Language, Race, and Styles of Youth Identity. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. "Cliques, crowds, and crews: Social labels in racial space." 42-66. (A)

Raciolinguistics, 327-346 (Zentella, Networks).

Writing skills presentation by Professor Benor

Midterm quiz

Immigrant languages; translanguaging; linguistic landscape

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 24

Otheguy, Ricardo, Ofelia García, & Wallis Reid. 2015. "Clarifying Translanguaging and Deconstructing Named Languages: A Perspective from Linguistics." Applied Linguistics Review 6/3: 281-307.

Shohamy, Elana & Durr Gorter, eds. 2009. Linguistic Landscape: Expanding the Scenery. New York: Routledge. Introduction (1-10). (A)

Student presentation

Sunday, October 27, 11:59pm: Proposals for Assignment #3 due via Blackboard

Native American languages; heritage language maintenance and shift

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 29

Language, Chapter 12 (253-277).

- Hinton, Leanne. 2001. "Language Revitalization: An Overview." In The Green Book of Language Revitalization in Practice. Leanne Hinton and Ken Hale, eds. San Diego: Academic Press. 3-18. (A)

Student presentation

Whiteness, diverse white speech styles, slang, and white privilege; Halloween costumes

THURSDAY, OCTOBER 31

- Bucholtz, Mary. 2011. White Kids: Language, Race, and Styles of Youth Identity. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. "Say word? Race and style in white teenage slang." 67-89. (A)

Student presentation

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 5

- Foster, Deborah. 2014. "A Guide to White Privilege for White People Who Think They've Never Had Any." Politicus USA. <http://www.politicususa.com/2014/01/26/guide-white-privilege-white-people-theyve.html>.
- Blake, John. 2016. "It's Time to Talk About 'Black Privilege.'" CNN. <http://www.cnn.com/2016/03/30/us/black-privilege/index.html>.

Student presentation

Latinos, Spanglish

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 7

Language, Chapter 10 (209-225)

- Watch before class: Videos on the categories "Latino" and "Hispanic": be prepared to discuss what's missing from each: Divinity: Why? <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C2B5dM02aDc>;
- Kat Lazo: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gs2tdj2la8Y>

To be distributed and read in class: Excerpts from Anzaldúa, Gloria. 1999(1987). Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza.

Comedy excerpt shown in class: George Lopez, "Spanglish": <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2dxWkYMOGO>

Student presentation

Sunday, November 10: By now you should have notes on 5+ articles and an outline of your paper (not turned in)

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 12

Raciolinguistics, 135-150 (Mendoza-Denton, Gangs).

Raciolinguistics, 273-289 (Bucholtz, Name).

Comedy excerpt shown in class: Key and Peele, "Substitute Teacher": <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Dd7FixovKBw>

Student presentation

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 14

Raciolinguistics, 65-80 (Rosa, Spanglish).

Raciolinguistics, 255-272 (Perez et al., Zapotec).

Student presentation

Sunday, November 17, 11:59pm: Assignment #3 complete draft due via Blackboard (for peer review)

Jewish Americans

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 19

Benor, Sarah Benor. 2011. "Wensch, bentsh, and balagan: Variation in the American Jewish linguistic repertoire." Language and Communication 31/2:141-154. (A)

Raciolinguistics, 171-184 (Benor, Performing).

South Asian Americans

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 21

Raciolinguistics, 221-237 (Sharma, Punjabi).

Shankar, Shalini. 2008. Post Lindt: Teen Culture, Class, and Success in Silicon Valley. Durham: Duke University Press. "Desi Fashions of Speaking" (100-118). (A)

Comedy excerpt shown in class: Master of None

Sunday, November 24, 11:59pm: Peer review of Assignment #3 due via Blackboard

Asian Americans

TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 26

Raciolinguistics, 81-96 (Chun, Ching-Chong).

Raciolinguistics, 97-111 (Lo, Village).

Comedy excerpts shown in class:

Margaret Cho, "Race": <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k6mLwKc0A2Ig>;

Jimmy Wong, "Ching Chong: Asians in the Library response song": <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zuEMWV3sVA>

THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 28

No class: Thanksgiving

TUESDAY, DECEMBER 3

Raciolinguistics, 309-326 (Reyes, Korean).

Video on Hawaiian Pidgin to be shown in class:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O7X8AAedC4>, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GlmQSR3Ei0>, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7zypVPl7F4>

Wednesday, December 4, 11:59pm: Assignment #3 final draft due via Blackboard

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 5

No reading

In-class review

Thursday, December 12, 1pm: Final exam (take-home) due via Blackboard

Assignments

All assignments should be double spaced and should have page numbers and a heading with the paper title and the student's name. For citations, any consistent parenthetical (not footnotes) system can be used (e.g., Chicago, APA, MLA). The bibliography at the end of the paper should include author, year of publication, article title, journal or book title, and URL if it was accessed online.

Assignment #1 (2-3 pages):

Describe your identity in terms of race/ethnicity (and, optionally, other dimensions), and discuss how it relates to language.

To help you get started, consider some of these guiding questions:

Who are you in relation to the social categories of race and ethnicity, as well as, optionally, gender, age, socioeconomic status, sexuality, religion, location, and/or ancestral heritage? Which of these categories are important to how you see yourself and how you think you are viewed by others? Why and how? What role does language play in how you see yourself and how others see you? What roles do physical appearance, music, home decoration, and/or food play? What strategies do you use to deal with any tensions between multiple aspects of your identity?

I am not looking for straight answers to these questions; they are merely here to guide you in addressing the underlined prompt above. If race/ethnicity is not central to how you understand your identity, you can focus more on other dimensions (gender, age, etc.); even so, please make sure to discuss your race/ethnicity, the way you talk, and how you differ from people of other racial/ethnic groups. I am looking for evidence that you absorbed the concepts covered in the first weeks of class and are thinking deeply about race, identity, and language. Be yourself, and be creative. This paper could take the form of an essay, a letter, a dramatic monologue or dialogue, a poem, or something else. Your writing should be concrete and should include specific anecdotes or interactions. Don't just say "I speak differently" or "she used Ebonics." Give examples of specific linguistic features (e.g., "She said things like, 'They going home'. Finally, make sure to be clear and concise in your writing. After you write the paper, set it aside and come back with fresh eyes to edit it twice, checking for consistency, clarifying any ambiguous wording, and removing extraneous words, phrases, or even paragraphs. Bibliographic citations are not expected for this assignment.

You will be graded using the following rubric:

- (30 points) Discussion of identity, ethnicity, and language demonstrates understanding of early class concepts
- (20 points) Structure, including unifying argument or concept, logical organization, and appropriate transitions
- (20 points) Writing style: clarity, conciseness, word choice, no repetition or unnecessary words
- (20 points) Mechanics: grammar, tense, punctuation, spelling, format
- (10 points) Creativity and engaging writing

Assignment #2 (in pairs):

Analysis of a film or TV show, focusing on issues of language and identity, to be presented in class and written up in 5-6 pages. This assignment is to be done in pairs. Your essay should have a unifying thesis about ethnicity, identity, inter-group relations, transitions, or some combination of these elements, and you should support this thesis in part with analysis of language. Here are some questions you might consider as you work on your analysis:

- [] How does your selected work use language to represent an ethnic, immigrant, or other social group or the relations between groups?
- [] How do the characters change over the course of the film? Do they change their sense of self? Do they progress from one class/group/society into another?
- [] How are the characters depicted as belonging to two or more groups? Do they experience a sense of double consciousness? Do they feel as if they are stuck in a borderlands?
- [] How does the film portray conflict between groups or generations?

As part of your analysis, please discuss at least two of the following sociolinguistic phenomena (which will be discussed in detail in class) as they are portrayed in your selected work:

- Intra-speaker variation: Sociolinguistic variation among characters according to socio-economic class, ethnicity, gender, age, sexual orientation, generation from immigration, etc.
- Intra-speaker variation: Individual style shifting or code switching (according to situation, audience, or topic) used to negotiate identities
- Metalinguistic: conversation involving language ideology and/or language discrimination: Conversation about language that represents (possibly conflicting) understandings of how language is or should be used and sometimes leads to negative consequences for certain speakers and privilege for others

Please include some linguistic analysis: give examples of distinctive features, offering quotes as evidence where appropriate. If any of the readings we have done are relevant to your analysis, please cite them. There is no need to cite additional scholarship.

Some ideas for films/shows to select:

BlackKkLantern, Green Book, Sorry to Bother You, The Hate You Give, Crazy Rich Asians, Coco, Princess and the Frog, Get Out, Orange is the New Black, Master of None, Blackish, Fresh Off the Boat, Jane the Virgin, This Is Us, Down to Earth, Barbershop, My Big Fat Greek